

United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees
(UNHCR)

Thomas Jefferson Model United Nations Conference

TechMUN XXXIII



High School General Assembly

Co-Chairs: Surbhi Singla and Emily Toth

Thomas Jefferson High School for Science and Technology

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Dear Delegates,

It is with immense pleasure that we welcome you to TechMUN XXXIII and the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees. We are excited for a weekend of debate on some of UNHCR's top issues: *Combatting Human Trafficking and Exploitation in Refugee Populations* and *Addressing Food Insecurity in Refugee Camps*. In particular, this committee will aim to delve into the responses our world takes after disasters and their potential humanitarian impacts.

This weekend we are looking for delegates with innovative ideas to present and hope that every one of you will have a strong presence in committee to ensure debate is constantly flowing. As co-chairs, we would like to see eloquent, substance-filled speeches, along with exceptional leadership, teamwork, and diplomacy. While the committee is a place of debate, it is of utmost importance to be considerate and respectful of other delegates. We also place a high value on creativity and specificity to avoid overlap and repetitiveness. We encourage you to think out of the box for solutions and to address multiple groups and demographics in your working papers. Specificity during this conference will be of the utmost importance, as it demonstrates your knowledge of the issue and delves into the nuances of such important topics.

We hope that every one of you steps out of your comfort zone this weekend. Most importantly, don't give up at any point in committee — one mess-up is not the end of the world. Ultimately, we know how it feels like to participate in committee for hours on end, so don't be afraid to make mistakes and try new things. Whether this is your first conference or you are a seasoned delegate, we hope to make this TechMUN as fun as possible. If you have any questions, don't hesitate to email unhcrtechmun2026@gmail.com.

Surbhi Singla & Emily Toth

Co-Chairs, United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees

Topic A: Combatting Human Trafficking and Exploitation in Refugee Populations

Introduction:

Human trafficking, or modern-day slavery, is a severe human rights violation affecting millions worldwide. It involves the recruitment, transportation, transfer, harboring, or receipt of individuals through force, fraud, or coercion for the purpose of exploitation. Children are particularly vulnerable, making up a significant portion of trafficking victims globally. Child trafficking occurs in various forms, including forced labor, sexual exploitation, and involvement in criminal activities. Understanding its complexities is crucial for effective prevention and intervention efforts. The United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime (UNODC) reported nearly 70,000 identified trafficking victims in 2022, with children accounting for 38%. However, due to challenges in detection and reporting, the actual number is likely much higher.

Refugees are categorized as being at high risk for becoming victims of human trafficking, mainly due to their extreme vulnerability. Refugees have lost their community safety nets and are often socially isolated in unfamiliar environments, such as refugee camps. Furthermore, refugees are often economically desperate and are more willing to take false offers of jobs, housing, or travel.

Human trafficking of refugees takes many forms, and one of the most common is forced labor, where victims are coerced into work under threat, debt bondage, or exploitative conditions. Forced labor trafficking often occurs in situations where refugees lack legal work opportunities. Sexual exploitation, most commonly experienced by women and girls, involves prostitution under coercion and exploitation through forced or “temporary” marriages. Finally, many refugees pay smugglers to cross borders and acquire smuggling debts, which they are forced to

pay off by working under a trafficker. Unaccompanied and separated children are at an especially high risk of trafficking and exploitation.

Trafficking of refugees is especially prominent in refugee camps, as overcrowding makes it difficult for authorities to monitor the population, camp workers often abuse their power, aid is irregular, and refugees turn to other methods to receive basic necessities, and limited security and legal enforcement make it easier for traffickers to operate with impunity. Sexual exploitation is common in camps, as women with few economic options may be pressured into exchanging sex for food and shelter when humanitarian support is insufficient. Camp workers may exploit refugees' need for legal status by threatening to withhold registration cards for medical services unless the refugee "works" for them. Refugees are often reluctant to report this abuse, as it could jeopardize their access to protection or services.

Past Actions:

The 1951 Refugee Convention provided a basis for preventing human trafficking and abuse of refugees, as it recognizes their right to protection and non-refoulement. In 2000, the UN passed the Palermo Protocol to legally define different forms of trafficking, and obliged states to protect vulnerable populations, such as refugees, from exploitation.

Many UN agencies, such as the UNHCR, IOM, and UNICEF, have developed refugee protection frameworks that monitor camps for abuse and provide safe reporting systems. For instance, the UNHCR/NGO hotline system provides a safe and anonymous way for refugees to report sexual abuse and labor exploitation. UNICEF and UNHCR have implemented child protection programs in refugee camps to identify and support unaccompanied and separated children through education, safe spaces, and family training programs. UNICEF estimates that over 500,000 refugee children have benefited from these protective services.

The UN implemented a zero-tolerance policy regarding sexual exploitation and abuse among its staff in refugee camps. This involved training for UN staff and partners on preventing exploitation of refugees, as well as investigation units to address complaints of abuse. Furthermore, UNHCR has dedicated sexual abuse and exploitation officers in camps to ensure refugees' safety.

Current Situation:

Human trafficking has increased in recent years, and refugees have seen an increased risk of becoming victims in certain regions. UNICEF estimates that 3 in every 5 child migrants and refugees traveling from Central America and the Caribbean are victims of human trafficking. IOM estimates that 80% of female refugees from Nigeria were targeted for sexual exploitation, 37% of migrants from high-risk migration routes have been trafficked, and over 10% of refugees in European reception centers are currently being trafficked.

This issue has been exacerbated by funding cuts and reduced services in refugee camps, which indirectly push more refugees, specifically women, into vulnerable situations where they are more likely to be trafficked. While the UNHCR has a zero-tolerance policy regarding sexual exploitation in refugee centers, victims rarely speak up due to fears of retaliation, loss of service, and general stigma.

Possible Solutions:

Addressing the human trafficking and sexual exploitation of refugees requires a multifaceted approach. Countries must enhance protection systems within camps and simultaneously strengthen legal protection for refugees, as they are often exploited due to not being able to work legally. It is essential for countries to address child protection and the

breaking up of families, as these factors greatly increase the chance of trafficking. Furthermore, countries must address groups and geographical areas that are at a higher risk of exploitation.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can we empower refugees economically without exposing them to exploitation or unsafe work?
2. What camp design or operational changes could reduce vulnerability to exploitation?
3. How can we measure and monitor the effectiveness of interventions against exploitation?
4. How can funding gaps and resource limitations be addressed to ensure long-term protection and aid?

Helpful Links:

- <https://www.unhcr.org/us/what-we-do/protect-human-rights/asylum-and-migration/trafficking-persons>
- <https://help.unhcr.org/global/human-trafficking/>
- <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/press/releases/2024/December/unodc-global-human-trafficking-report-detected-victims-up-25-per-cent-as-more-children-are-exploited-and-forced-labour-cases-spike.html>
- <https://www.unhcr.org/us/media/considerations-issue-human-trafficking-perspective-international-refugee-law-and-unhcrs>
- <https://www.unhcr.org/us/news/press-releases/new-unhcr-iom-mmrc-report-highlights-extreme-horrors-faced-refugees-and-migrants>

Topic B: Addressing Food Insecurity in Refugee Camps

Introduction:

Food insecurity involves the lack of reliable access to sufficient, safe, and nutritious food. Food insecurity leads to effects such as malnutrition, stunted growth, weakened immune systems, autoimmune disorders, and death.

Refugee camps are temporary settlements that are quickly created to respond to a crisis. Because of this, camps are often overcrowded with little room for fresh food to be grown, and instead, water shortages, poor sanitation, and supply issues. The dense population of refugee camps places a strain on local markets, increasing food prices for both the camps and the communities around them. Most camps rely on assistance from agencies such as the WFP and UNHCR to meet minimum calorie and nutritional needs, but this assistance has not been sustainable in the long-run, particularly for children, pregnant women, and ill individuals, as global funding gaps are common and small non-profits struggle to make a true impact. Furthermore, shortened funding has led to rations falling below daily caloric requirements. For instance, refugee camps in Ethiopia cut food rations to 40% of full needs, leaving refugees with less than 1000 calories per day.

Even when refugee camps have food, contamination is common. Biological contamination, particularly in tropical climates, leads to foodborne illnesses. Physical contamination involves unsanitary storage and handling of the food and, in addition to cross-contamination, is increasingly common in camps. Poor sanitation of the camps increases the spread of food and water-borne diseases. These issues are exacerbated as food storage is difficult, refugee hygiene is hard to maintain, food preparation areas are increasingly susceptible to contamination, camps are underfunded and lack resources, and overcrowding is common.

Refugee camps' food supplies are greatly impacted by the wider global context. Ongoing wars and instability disrupt supply chains, especially when the camp is located in a country with limited economic resources and food infrastructure. Furthermore, climate shocks such as floods and droughts can reduce crop yields and contaminate stored food.

Past Actions:

The United Nations World Food Program (WFP) was established in 1961 to provide emergency food aid to refugee camps and appeal to donor funding to prevent ration cuts. The WFP's main strategy is to increase cash and voucher programs for refugee populations and to encourage them to support local vendors. The WFP collaborates with the UNHCR to prevent and reduce malnutrition and provide targeted assistance to refugee populations.

Current Situation:

2025 saw a slight decrease in the refugee population, with 117.3 million displaced persons, 42.5 million of whom were refugees. In 2024, over 295 million people across 53 countries experienced acute hunger, meaning they lacked enough food to meet minimum nutritional needs. A majority of acute hunger is driven by displacement and conflict, which has only grown in the past years due to regional conflicts. 95 million forcibly displaced persons live in areas experiencing acute food insecurity, meaning that the majority of refugee camps cannot provide for their population.

Within the past 2 years, global food prices have seen great increases, making it difficult for agencies and camps to buy and preserve food. Funding gaps for humanitarian aid have

greatly decreased. In 2025, the *FAO-WFP Global Report on Food Crisis* estimated that, out of the \$29 billion needed to assist those at risk of acute hunger, only \$10.5 billion has been provided. This is largely due to competing budget priorities of donors, as well as donor fatigue and economic pressures.

Possible Solutions:

Addressing the challenges of supporting refugee populations requires a comprehensive approach. Countries must address humanitarian funding gaps and disrupted food supply chains. Additionally, countries should consider how to support both refugee populations and local vendors and farmers. Furthermore, countries should work to strengthen solutions for long-term sustainability.

Questions to Consider:

1. How can we ensure refugee populations receive the adequate amount of food while not being over-relying on foreign exports?
2. What international guidelines or frameworks could support refugee camps?
3. How can we support malnourished refugee populations with dietary restrictions?
4. How can we ensure long-term sustainability in refugee camps?
5. How can we ensure partnerships between refugee camps and organizations do not become exploitative?

Helpful Links:

- <https://wfpusa.org/work/people/refugees/>
- <https://www.unhcr.org/us/what-we-do/protect-human-rights/public-health/nutrition-and-food-security>

- <https://www.unicef.org/press-releases/acute-food-insecurity-and-malnutrition-rise-sixth-consecutive-year-worlds-most#main-content>
- <https://www.wfp.org/news/refugees-escaping-sudan-face-escalating-hunger-and-malnutrition-food-aid-risks-major>



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